

Drug use and abuse

Drugs are chemical substances taken by people for various reasons. They affect the body and brain, and may have a short- or long-term impact on a person's mental state and physical well-being.

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Types of drugs 168–169 ▶

Peer pressure 192–193 ▶

Why people use drugs

People have been experimenting with drugs for medicinal, spiritual, or recreational purposes for thousands of years. People who use drugs recreationally—for the purpose of getting “high”—tend to use them as a form of escapism, or because it makes them feel good; but it can be easy to lose control and depend on those drugs.

Most countries have laws about the manufacture, sale, and misuse of drugs. If teens are caught with drugs or selling drugs, they could end up with a criminal record, which can make other areas of their life more difficult.

TEEN HINTS

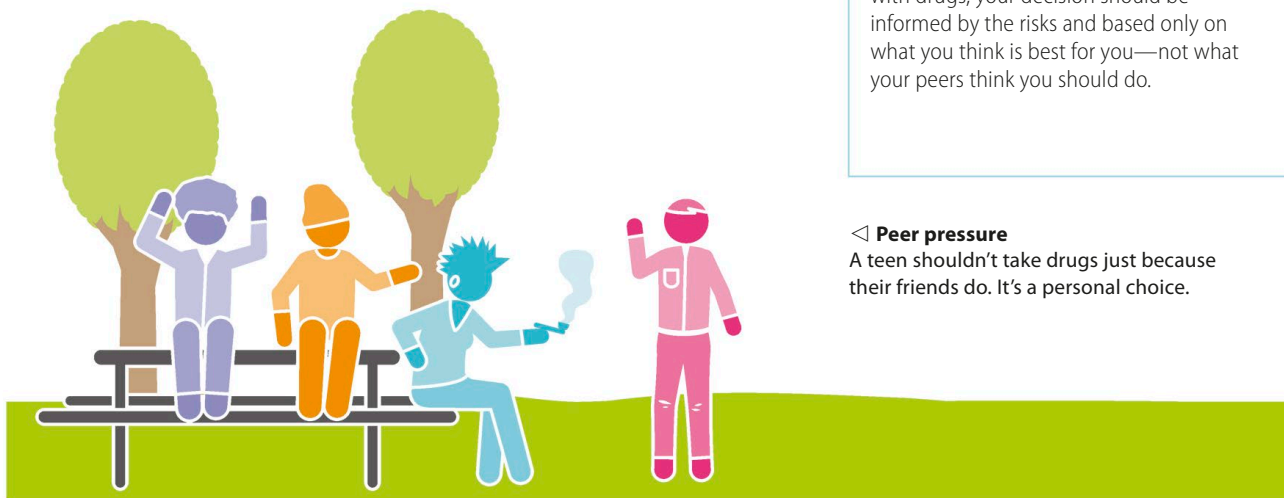
Making the decision

Some people first try drugs because they are curious about the effects. Others use drugs because they feel under pressure from their friends, or they worry about being judged if they don't join in.

If you are thinking about experimenting with drugs, your decision should be informed by the risks and based only on what you think is best for you—not what your peers think you should do.

◀ Peer pressure

A teen shouldn't take drugs just because their friends do. It's a personal choice.



Risks and dangers

Drugs may invoke pleasurable feelings in the short term, but they can have harmful effects, both when they are being taken and in the long term.

▽ At risk

There is a wide variety of risks associated with taking drugs. Here are just some.

Addiction

Poor mental and physical health

Bad decision-making

Broken relationships

Impact on studies

Criminal charges